

TABLE 2

Managing Discussions with Patients About Unnecessary Antibiotics

Step	Examples
Explain why antibiotics will not help	"The common cold is caused by a virus, so antibiotics won't help." "Antibiotics can't fight viruses like colds. Taking them won't do any good this time and may hurt their chances of fighting bacterial infections you might get in the future."
Suggest treatments that might help	"You can try honey for your cough, ibuprofen or acetaminophen for your muscle aches, and nasal or oral decongestants with or without an antihistamine for your congestion."
Manage expectations for length of illness	"Cold viruses can make you feel lousy. Most people start to feel better after about a week, but sometimes the cough can last even longer, especially if you smoke." "It is common for children and adults (especially those around young children) to seem sick throughout the entire fall and winter. You can catch one cold virus right after another, like planes taking off at a busy airport. The good news is that you should not get those same viruses again."
Discuss next steps if patient does not improve	"If you develop worsening symptoms like a fever higher than 101°F (38.3°C), productive cough, shortness of breath, or very bad headache or facial pain, call my office so we can make sure you don't have a more serious illness."

